

House Panel Votes to Hold Epstein Associate Leon Black in Contempt

The billionaire investor skipped a deposition this month and sued to block subpoenas from the Oversight Committee.



Oversight Committee Chairman James Comer, right, and ranking member Rep. Robert Garcia. (Tom Williams/CQ Roll Call via AP Images)

By Stephen Neukam

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Billionaire investor Leon Black should be held in contempt of Congress, the House Oversight Committee declared Tuesday, voting unanimously to refer his case to the full House after he stood up a subpoena in the Jeffrey Epstein investigation earlier this month.

Investigators on the panel say their interest in Black lies in his relationship with Epstein and potential nondisclosure agreements he may have signed with women related to the Epstein investigation.

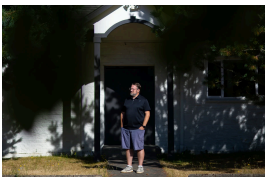
Black [skipped a scheduled deposition](#) with the panel two weeks ago, and sued the House Oversight Committee. Black’s lawsuit in federal court alleges the subpoenas are invalid and seek private information that has no “legitimate connection” to the committee’s work.

“Mr. Black is hiding behind litigation to delay having to provide answers to the American people,” said committee Chairman James Comer (R-Kentucky) at the meeting Tuesday. “Subpoenas are not suggestions. They carry the force of law and require full compliance.”

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The bipartisan vote to advance the contempt proceedings sets the stage for a full House vote on the measure. Black’s representatives did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

[Black](#), a longtime Epstein associate, told lawmakers in an initial interview in June that he had no knowledge of Epstein’s crimes, but was aware of his 2008 sex crime conviction. Lawmakers are investigating Epstein and his network of allies, and have interviewed other powerful people including tech billionaire Bill Gates, former U.S. Attorney General Pam Bondi and U.S. Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick.

The contempt proceedings against Black are a rare moment of bipartisanship in an investigation that has turned [increasingly partisan](#). Comer has signaled he plans to wrap up his probe in the coming months, while Democrats are promising to keep digging if they win the majority in November.

“This committee has tried to work with him to get answers, but he’s had no interest in cooperating,” Rep. Robert Garcia (D-California), the top Democrat on the committee, said. “I do want to thank Chairman Comer for his efforts.”

AUTHOR

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